



free will
and
determinism

against
compatibilist
free will

A large red circle with a slight drop shadow, containing white text. The text is arranged in three lines, centered within the circle.

**against
incompatibilist
free will**

1. No one has any choice about events which happened in the distant past.
 2. No one has any choice about DINOSAUR.
(1)
 3. If determinism is true, then only one future is consistent with the state of the world at a time + the laws of nature.
 4. If determinism is true, then the laws of nature say that if DINOSAUR happens, then DECISION happens. (3)
 5. No one has any choice about what the laws of nature are.
 6. If determinism is true, then no one has any choice about the fact that if DINOSAUR then DECISION. (4,5)
 7. If no one has about choice about whether P, and no one has any choice about whether, if P, then Q, then no one has any choice about whether Q.
-

C. If determinism is true, then no one has any choice about DECISION. (2,6,7)

This argument seems to show that the combination of four theses — that No one has any choice about the past, no choice about the laws of nature, the no choice principle, and determinism — rules out free will.

Since the first three of these theses seem quite plausible, the argument seems to show that if determinism is true, there are no free actions — and hence that free will is incompatible with determinism.

The consequence argument

1. Free will is incompatible with determinism.
 2. If Libertarianism is true, then there is no free will.
-

C. There is no free will.

The master argument against the reality of free will

Real/|the master argument:

The consequence argument is a defense of premise (1). If you believe in free will, and find the consequence argument persuasive, it looks tempting to reply to the master argument by denying premise (2).

But, we'll see now, this argument can also be given a plausible defense.

One way to introduce this defense is with the following quote from

David Hume:

Hume's basic thought is that there is a big difference between free actions and actions which are random or chance.

Here's a thought experiment:

Now ask yourself: is Alex's choice free? It seems very clear that it is not. It is undetermined by facts prior to the relevant run of the Randomizer, but it is random. It is not up to Alex what he does; and free actions have to be up to the person doing the action.

This suggests:

But now consider the idea that free will requires the falsity of determinism. If this is true, then it must be that free actions (or their immediate causes) are undetermined:

1. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there are free actions, those actions are undetermined by anything prior to the action.
2. If an action is undetermined, then the agent does not control whether it happens.
3. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there are free actions, the agent does not control whether they happen. (1,2)
4. If an act is free, then the agent must control whether it happens.

C. If Libertarianism is true, then there are no free actions. (3,4)

THE CONTROL ARGUMENT

Libertarianism is the view that
free will is real and
incompatible with
determinism. So, if the
conclusion of this argument is
true, Libertarianism is false.

How should the Libertarian
reply to this argument?



1. No one has any choice about events which

then DECISION happens. (3)

3. If determined, the only one

varlatatie + the last of the

then DECISION. (4,5)

2. None has any choice about DIDS. ATJR.

nature say that if DINS ARE happy,

and none has any choice about whether,

future is not as it was with the state of the

happened in the distant past.



6. If $\det A$ is true, then A has any

5. No one has any choice about what the laws

C. If determinist is true, then no one has any

7. If none has about choice about whether P ,

about whether @.

of interest.

choice about DECISION (2, 6, 7)

theorie about the fact that if DNR

4. If determinism is true, the laws of



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reality of free will.

We can lay out this puzzle in terms of the following master argument against the



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1. If Libertarian is true, then,

2. If an action is undertaken,

must control whether it happens.

agent does not control whether

C: If Libertarianism is true, then

they happen. $(1, 2)$

3. If Libertarian is true, then,

if there are friends, the

anything prior to the action.

what her ^{it} happens.

4. If an act is free, then the agent



there are no free actions. $(3, 4)$

then the agent does not control

activities are undertaken by

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conclusion of this argument is

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incompatible with

Libertarians insist that

reply to this argument?

How should the Libertarian

believe in free will rejects premise (2).

Compatibility believers in free will reject premise (1). An incompatibilist

Now, so far we have been given no reason to think that either premise (2)

or premise (3) is true. We're now going to look at two arguments — one

for (2), and one for (3).

A large, solid orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "against compatibilist free will" is written in white, bold, lowercase letters, arranged in three lines.

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The master argument against the reality of free will



The consequence argument



But consider what an understatement it would be

up to that point is consistent with the act either happening or

not happening. So if the act happens, nothing makes it

an action which is such that the entire history of the universe

action, or anyone else, makes the action happen.

happen. In particular, nothing that persons who do the



2. If an action is undetermined, then it is

are free actions, those actions are



unleashed.

raindon.(1,2)

no free actors.

C. If Libertarianism is true, there are

3. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there

1. If Libertarian is true, then, if there

4. No irreflexive acts are free.

raindrops.



